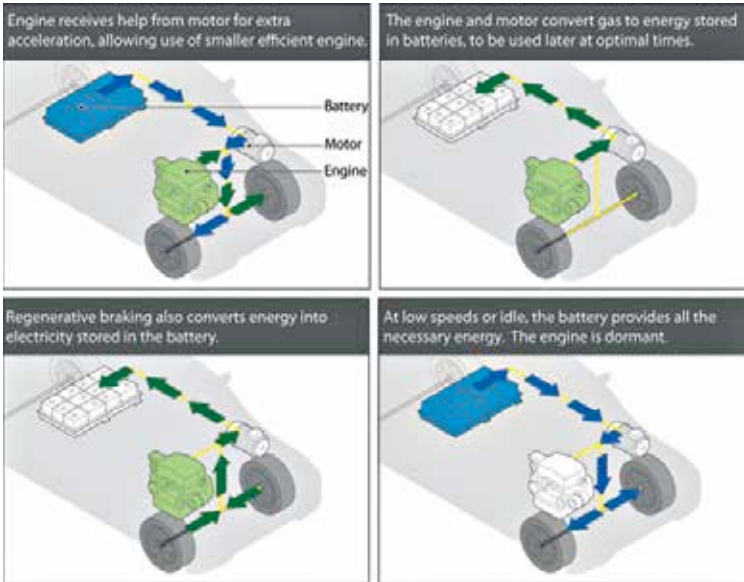




Regenerative Braking ensures efficient use of both the fuel and electric motor

wasted) a portion of the fuel's energy is transferred to the car's battery, thereby charging it on the go.

While hybrid cars have their own merits, they're not quite as energy efficient as they're made out to be. Hybrid alternatives typically cost about 30% more than their conventional counterparts, but the savings in fuel costs are not always proportional. Studies on the 2003 model of the Honda Civic Hybrid against its conventional model showed a very slight increase in fuel efficiency – the hybrid offered 36 miles per gallon as opposed to 29 miles for the regular (non-hybrid) version. Consumer reports have shown that in order to generate significant savings, one would have to use a hybrid car continuously for more than 20 years.

The unique braking-charging phenomenon also means that hybrids are suited for driving conditions which require you to brake often, as in a city. This is the reverse of what is generally observed with conventional vehicles. In turn, significant fuel and energy savings can be realized only in the appropriate conditions, and if you intend to use your vehicle for a lot of long distance trips, you're probably better off practicing some smart driving in your existing car itself.